

Episode 187: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 14

When this manuscript is updated, I'll actually be in China. For location hunting for a certain new TV series, the director, art staff, and I are heading to somewhere in China. Ah, China after a long time. It's been several years since I've been to China outside of Hong Kong, and this time it's somewhat rural.

However, both the director and I are super busy. What we managed to squeeze out was a 3-night, 4-day forced schedule. Departing Narita early morning and arriving locally firmly at night. Plus time difference feelings. Plus domestic flight connections and such - some heart-pounding moments!

In such a situation, will we actually be able to return properly? (No, we're not going that deep into the wilderness (laugh))

That work is still before information release, but maybe we can announce it in autumn? Please look forward to that too!

Now then.

Episode 12: "The Circle Around Us" Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko & Shibata Katsunori, Direction/Shibata Katsunori, Colour Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Shoma begins telling how losing Momoka was his fault. The "incident" from 16 years ago as told by Shoma. The memories of that day, that incident are revealed. Surprised and confused Ringo. Himari collapses and is carried to the hospital. Kanba rushes there, but Himari dies. And Mario appears. Such was Episode 12.

Finally the major turning point from first half to second half.

The outline of the "incident" told on the "95 Train" continuing from Episode 11. Processing inside the car continues from Episode 11. In Episode 12, the penguins also stop their movement - are they intently listening to Shoma's story, or are they literally turning their backs? Such a first half with heavy, oppressive air dominating the car interior.

The "incident" flashback beginning with Shoma's narration is drawn from young Tabuki's perspective midway through, and how to handle this flashback scene's screen was Episode 12's first challenge. *Mawaru Penguindrum* builds up its story using many flashback scenes, but by inserting "out of service boards" modelled after subways at the beginning of flashback scenes, we basically eliminated special processing for flashback scenes (like frames within screens common to flashback scenes). In previous episodes, for flashback scenes we basically didn't do anything particularly special besides colour changes matching time periods and locations.

Now this time, since the incident being treated as a motif is what it is, while some degree of realism was necessary, the theme wasn't exactly identifying and recreating that incident or place - so how far exactly should we draw it? For the few early morning cuts just before the incident, I believe the art boards that first came up had Tokyo landmarks drawn in quite realistically, but the director gave correction instructions to "show it more with silhouettes only." Since it's fine if being Tokyo is somehow conveyed, we went with more silhouette-like drawing. We also dramatically lowered the overall screen saturation, making Ping Force members in orange windbreakers stand out strangely in greyish screens.

From midway through the flashback, it's told from young Tabuki's perspective at that time. Since that morning began as the same daily routine as always, while somewhat suppressing saturation, this side was finished as a relatively normal screen. Then we created a sharp drop to heavy screens at the boundary of helicopter silhouettes flying about.

In this series of flashback scenes, the number one contributor was definitely the "Picto-sans" - various pictograms by Osakabe. Orange jacket Ping Force Picto-sans, confused customers and subway staff Picto-sans in front of Higashi-Koenji Station. Moreover, variations with movement like carrying boxes and shouting through megaphones - we ordered these from our site... while being somewhat reserved, we went all out (laugh). Since we ordered so many, we decided to do what we could ourselves, so for the funeral scene's mourning dress Picto-sans, I created them by processing previously appeared Picto-sans.

Now, what finally appeared in this funeral scene was Momoka. Her first appearance was as a portrait photo, but the story of Momoka's colours will be revisited in later episodes.

After Himari was carried to the hospital, I created overall heavy screens. ICU inside and outside - the corridor where Shoma and Ringo keep watch with lighting reduced and darkened, while ICU interior was in pale whitish light like Himari's life growing thin. Both aimed for screens with lowered saturation but properly showing colour tone.

Crystal World space also matched Himari's life state, creating a dark, nearly stopped space. For this scene's colour tone image, I had them output normal Crystal World space 3D images as PSD format with layers intact, and processed that image data myself to create samples. I also decided character colour tones accordingly. Honestly there were parts where I was making quite unreasonable processing orders to photography, but photography put it together into even better atmosphere.

And Episode 12's second half highlight was "Mary's Lamb." This was the scene that took the longest to finalise in Episode 12.

The sheep design was by Shibata. They were simply cute, too cute individually, so how to balance this with the art became quite high-hurdle work. This series of art was by Nakamura Chieko. During this episode's production crunch, Nakamura came to the staff room repeatedly right up to the last train at midnight, bringing gradually completed work for checking. I layered characters over those backgrounds and created sample images built up considering cut-to-cut connections and cut

buildup, having photography reproduce and compile them. The cuter they are, the more beautiful they are, the more cruel an impression is born. While there wasn't much time, gradually. Matching such art, we gradually decided the depth of image processing and the goddess's colours and processing.

And the dark rabbit had returned.

Such an Episode 12 that can't be fully described (laugh).

Incidentally, as a digression, about the elementary school Momoka and Tabuki attended - what should we do about its school emblem? For that, the elementary school's name had to be decided first. So, Kagaya Elementary School. We borrowed production staff member Kagaya's surname (laugh).

(12.07.10)